

AK.3 Inspection Sequence

Which of your house actually gets inspected in Alaska — the answer is rarely "all of it" and rarely "none of it" — the order it happens in, and the record to keep for the stages nobody will ever look at.

Before you use this document

This is a process reference, not legal advice. Alaska has no statewide residential building code and, over most of its land area, no local building department either — so what binds your house is a short stack of *state* rules that apply whether or not anyone inspects, plus whatever your borough, your city, your lender and your utility require on top. Confirm every item with the office that will actually decide it before you rely on it. Where a borough or city enforces its own code, its permit card governs and lists the inspections your job requires.

THREE INSPECTION REGIMES, DRAWN ON THREE DIFFERENT LINES

There is no Alaska residential building code and therefore no statutory list of inspections. But "no code" does not mean "no inspector." Three separate regimes reach residential construction in this state, and **not one of them is drawn on a borough boundary**. They are drawn on the number of dwelling units in your building and the population of your community. Work out which apply to you before you assume either that everything will be inspected or that nothing will.

Who inspects what — and on which line

Regime	What it reaches	Authority
Local building department (borough or city, if any)	Everything — plan review, footings through final, and the certificate of occupancy — under whatever code that jurisdiction has adopted. Most of Alaska has none. Establish yours in AK.4 before reading further.	Local ordinance
State plumbing inspection DOLWD Mechanical Inspection	Plumbing, gas and fuel piping on new construction , in communities of 2,500 population and above — single-family houses included . Below 2,500 the community is statutorily exempt. This is the regime owner-builders are most often blindsided by, because it arrives where there is no building department at all.	AS 18.60.715(a); AS 18.60.735
State electrical inspection DOLWD Mechanical Inspection	"Public structures" and places of employment — which by definition means resident housing with more than one rental unit and similar. The Department describes its own scope as three-plex and above . Your single-family house is not inspected by the State — but the 2020 NEC still applies to it. See AK.1.	8 AAC 70.010; 8 AAC 70.090(4)

Who inspects what — and on which line

Regime	What it reaches	Authority
State Fire Marshal plan review	Buildings " <i>used for residential purposes containing four or more dwelling units</i> " and non-residential occupancies. The adopted code's own text excludes " <i>Detached one-, two-, and three-family dwellings.</i> " A house is outside it entirely.	AS 18.70.080(a)(2); 13 AAC 50.020

AS 18.60.715(a) — "The code applies to all new construction"; AS 18.60.735 — "An organized municipality or unorganized village having less than 2,500 population is exempt from the provisions of AS 18.60.705 — 18.60.740"; 8 AAC 70.010; 8 AAC 70.090(4); AS 18.70.080(a)(2); 13 AAC 50.020, adopting the 2021 IBC with Section 101.2 Exception 1. Scope descriptions confirmed against the Department of Labor and Workforce Development, Labor Standards and Safety Division, Mechanical Inspection Section — labor.alaska.gov → Labor Standards and Safety → Mechanical Inspection, read August 2026.

The one that surprises people: a state plumbing inspection with no building department in sight

An owner-builder in a Mat-Su or Interior community over 2,500 people typically concludes, correctly, that no government will review the house. Then a **State of Alaska** plumbing inspector arrives, because the plumbing code is not administered by the borough — it is administered by the Department of Labor and Workforce Development, and its trigger is **population, not jurisdiction**.

The code being enforced is the **2018 Uniform Plumbing Code**, adopted by regulation (8 AAC 63.010(a)(1)) as the minimum standard "*to be followed throughout the state.*" **Do not read the statute instead:** AS 18.60.705 still names the **1997** UPC on its face, because it adopts that edition "*unless the department adopts by regulation a later edition*" — and the department did. The statute is what a search engine hands you; the regulation is what the inspector is holding, and they are twenty-one years and seven editions apart.

And do not trust the state's own PDFs on the edition. The Department of Labor publishes consolidated statute-and-regulation booklets, and three of them are stale in three different directions: its *Electrical Safety* booklet still prints 8 AAC 70.025 as adopting the **2017** NEC when the live code adopts the **2020**; one plumbing PDF on its site prints the **2015** UPC; another prints the correct **2018**. Three official documents, three different answers, all linked from the same agency.

Confirm your community's population status before you rough in, and confirm every edition against the Administrative Code itself at akleg.gov. The population threshold is a real cliff: on one side the code and the inspection apply to your house, on the other the community is exempt outright.

Community: _____ Population / source: _____ State plumbing? Y / N: _____

WHAT A STATE PLUMBING PERMIT COSTS

Where the state plumbing code applies, permits "*will be issued on a fee basis in accordance with the schedule outlined in AS 18.60.720.*" That statute is a **ceiling**, not a price list — it says fees "*may not exceed*" the amounts it sets — and the amounts have not been revisited in a long time. For issuing each permit: **\$2.00**. Per plumbing fixture or trap: **\$1.50**. Building sewer: **\$5.00**. Private sewage disposal system: **\$10.00**. Water heater and vent: **\$1.50**. Gas piping system of one to five outlets: **\$1.50**.

Ask the Mechanical Inspection Section what it currently charges rather than assuming these figures are the invoice. The point worth carrying away is the shape of the thing: **the cost of this permit is never the reason to skip it**. Skipping it means an uninspected plumbing system in a house you will one day have to sell or insure.

8 AAC 63.020; AS 18.60.720(a)(1), (2)(A), (2)(B), (2)(E), (2)(F), (2)(G). Read at akleg.gov, August 2026. Confirm current charges with the Mechanical Inspection Section before budgeting.

Permit fee quoted: _____ By: _____ Date: _____

THE SEQUENCE — WHAT MUST BE COMPLETE BEFORE YOU CALL

Below is the order a new house on a frost-protected or deep foundation is normally built and checked in Alaska. Where a borough or city enforces a code, **your permit card governs** and may add or rename stages — confirm it at your first inspection. Where none does, work the same sequence anyway and record each stage yourself: the column that matters then is not "result" but "photographed."

Working Alaska residential sequence

Stage	What must be complete / what is verified	Who, if anyone
1. Site and layout	Setbacks and elevation confirmed against the survey, wastewater components staked clear of the building envelope and the drive, and any floodplain elevation requirement identified before excavation.	Local / AK.2
2. Excavation and subgrade	Bearing surface exposed and, on any site with permafrost risk, checked against the geotechnical report before anything is placed. This is the one stage in Alaska that cannot be corrected later at reasonable cost.	Geotech
3. Footing / foundation	Forms, reinforcing and any sub-slab or perimeter insulation in place before concrete. Confirm frost depth or the frost-protected shallow foundation detail from your design — Alaska frost depths vary enormously and no state figure exists.	Local
4. Under-slab and buried services	Under-slab drain, waste and vent piping under test; water service and any buried electrical in; vapor retarder and fill placed, before the pour. Where the state plumbing code applies this stage is a state inspection.	AS 18.60.715(a)

Working Alaska residential sequence

Stage	What must be complete / what is verified	Who, if anyone
5. Damp-proofing and backfill	Foundation waterproofing or damp-proofing applied and drainage placed before backfill. Backfilling early is the commonest way to lose a stage you cannot re-open.	Local
6. Plumbing rough-in	Water, waste and vent complete and under test; fuel gas piping pressure-tested. Inspected by the State in communities of 2,500 and above, and by your local department if one exists.	AS 18.60.715(a); 8 AAC 63.010
7. Mechanical rough-in	Heating distribution, combustion air, venting and equipment set. If you install a boiler or unfired pressure vessel, see the installation notice in AK.5 before you close the wall.	Local; AK.5
8. Electrical rough-in	Boxes, cable, panel, and the grounding electrode system in. Not inspected by the State on a single-family house — but the 2020 NEC still applies, and this is the stage a utility or a lender's inspector is most likely to ask about.	8 AAC 70.025(a)
9. Framing	Roof, framing, bracing, firestopping and sheathing complete, after the rough-ins so nothing has to be re-cut. Photograph every wall before it is covered.	Local
10. Insulation, air barrier and vapor retarder	Before any wall or ceiling covering. In this climate this is the stage that decides whether the house lasts , and in most of Alaska it is the stage with no inspector at all. Treat the self-record here as non-optional.	AK.2 energy
11. Finals — each trade	Plumbing and gas final where the state code applies; electrical and mechanical finals; building final and the certificate of occupancy where a local department issues one.	Local; state
12. Smoke and carbon monoxide alarms	Required in every dwelling unit in Alaska , code or no code — see AK.2. Verify type, placement and interconnection at final, and keep the receipt and a photograph.	AS 18.70.095; 13 AAC 50.030(b)

*Stages carrying a state citation are inspected by the State where the population threshold is met. Stages marked "Local" are common practice and are inspected only if a borough or city enforces a code — they are **not** Alaska law. Nothing in this sequence is a statutory list, because Alaska does not publish one for houses.*

YOUR RIGHTS WHEN A STATE INSPECTOR DOES COME

The plumbing statute gives an owner-builder two protections that are unusually explicit, and almost nobody invokes them.

- **A written notice that cites the code.** "A department inspector **shall** give written notice to the owner of a constructed premise or the contractor of a premise under construction of each violation of the code. The notice of violation **must accurately describe the violation and give specific reference to the section and paragraph of the code.** In addition, the notice must **prescribe the necessary changes** so that the work will comply with the code." You are entitled to know exactly which paragraph you failed, and to be told

what would fix it — in writing. (AS 18.60.725(a))

- **A fresh inspector if you think you were treated arbitrarily.** *"In case of complaints by a contractor, builder, or installer charging arbitrary actions or incompetence on the part of an inspector, the commissioner, after reviewing written presentation of the dispute, may require reinspection by a **new inspector who has no connection with either disputant.**"* Put the dispute in writing; the statute is built around a written presentation. (AS 18.60.725(b))

- **An appeal with a real clock.** A notice of violation *"is final unless the person affected or the owner or contractor of a construction premise affected files an appeal with the commissioner **within 30 days** after receipt of the notice,"* in writing, specifying the objections and the relief sought. (8 AAC 63.025(a))

What no Alaska statute gives you

There is **no deadline** anywhere in Alaska law for an inspector to appear after you request an inspection, and no deemed-approval remedy if one never does. Where a local department issues your permit, ask what its practice is and write it into AK.4. Where the State is your only inspector, build the wait into the schedule rather than into the critical path — the season is short enough already.

THE INSPECTION THAT CAN LEAVE YOU WITHOUT POWER

Two statutes let an inspection failure reach your utility service directly, and they run whether or not a building department exists.

On the **plumbing** side, the department *"may by regulation designate appropriate inspection to a public or private utility company,"* and *"a company so designated **may refuse utility connections** if an installation does not meet the requirements of this code."* (AS 18.60.710) On the **electrical** side, an authorized inspector gives written notice of each violation, and *"if within **15 days** after receipt of written notice ... the person notified does not rectify the condition, the inspector shall notify the electric utility ... Upon notice in writing from the inspector, the supplier of electrical power **may discontinue services** to the premises."* (AS 18.60.630)

Separately from any of that, **your utility sets its own conditions for energizing a new service**, and in unincorporated Alaska those conditions are often the only technical review your electrical work will ever receive. Ask your cooperative what it requires *before* you set the meter base, not after — the answer varies by utility and is not set by statute.

Utility: _____ Confirmed: _____

Requires before energizing: _____

INSPECTION AND SELF-VERIFICATION LOG

Fill this in as it happens, not from memory. Where an inspector came, record who and the result. **Where none did, that is the entry that matters most** — write the date you completed the stage, and note whether you photographed it. In Alaska this log and your photographs are frequently the only evidence that exists about how your house was built, and a lender, an insurer, an appraiser or a buyer will ask for exactly that in place of a certificate you were never issued.

Stage log — record every one, inspected or not

Stage	Who	Called	Done	Photos	Result / notes
Site & layout					
Excavation / subgrade					
Footing / foundation					
Under-slab services					
Damp-proof / backfill					
Plumbing rough					
Mechanical rough					
Electrical rough					
Framing					
Insulation / air barrier					
Final — plumbing					
Final — electrical					
Final — mechanical					
Final — building					
Smoke / CO alarms					

Certificate of occupancy issued (if any): _____ Number: _____

Sources — every Alaska claim in this document (verified August 2026)

What this document states	Authority
No statewide residential building code, and the adopted state code expressly excludes detached one-, two- and three-family dwellings	AS 18.70.080(a)(2); 13 AAC 50.020
The state plumbing code applies to all new construction, and communities under 2,500 population are exempt	AS 18.60.715(a); AS 18.60.735
The current statewide plumbing standard is the 2018 UPC by regulation, not the 1997 edition still named in the statute	8 AAC 63.010(a)(1); AS 18.60.705(a)
State electrical inspection reaches public structures and places of employment — not a single-family house	8 AAC 70.010; 8 AAC 70.090(4)
Statutory ceiling on state plumbing permit fees: \$2.00 to issue, \$1.50 per fixture, \$10.00 for a private sewage disposal system	8 AAC 63.020; AS 18.60.720(a)
Written notice of violation must cite the section and paragraph and prescribe the fix; a disputed inspection may be redone by an unconnected inspector; 30 days to appeal	AS 18.60.725(a), (b); 8 AAC 63.025(a)
A designated utility may refuse connection over plumbing; a power supplier may discontinue service 15 days after an unremedied electrical violation notice	AS 18.60.710; AS 18.60.630
Smoke and carbon monoxide alarms are required in every dwelling unit in the state	AS 18.70.095; 13 AAC 50.030(b)

Read any statute or regulation cited above free at **akleg.gov** → Bills & Laws → Alaska Statutes for an **AS** citation, or → Alaska Administrative Code for an **AAC** citation. Both are searchable by number — type 08.18.161 or 18 AAC 72 into the section box. Every quotation here was read there and verified August 2026 against the Alaska Statutes 2025 compilation.